

RAJ THACKERAY

This election will be a make-or-break contest for Raj

↑ Raj has modelled himself on the lines of Bal Thackeray, which helped him draw workers from the Shiv Sena and split the saffron vote in the LS polls. In this election too, he has to split enough of the vote to emerge kingmaker.

↓ An autocratic style of functioning and an unholy alliance with the Congress may end up deflecting some of the saffron vote. And if the MNS manages to play only the role of the spoiler and not get enough seats, it will end up losing its credibility.



THE MNS AND CONGRESS HAVE REACHED A QUIET UNDERSTANDING to defeat Sena candidates in key urban constituencies. The MNS is trying to increase its nuisance value by selling out to the highest bidder.

difficult to ensure a victory for Bandekar, a political novice.

In the Sewri seat, the Congress has fielded a first-timer Smita Chaudhary to facilitate a victory for MNS candidate Bala Nandgaokar against the Sena's Dagdu Sakpal. And in Bandra West, which is expected to be a straight fight between Baba Siddiqui of the Congress and Ashish Shelar of the BJP, the MNS is not fielding a candidate. A rather irate Uddhav says: "By offering his support to any government that comes to power, Raj is saying that he is up for sale. People will see through such individuals who are working for themselves and

have no real agenda. People who vote for small parties or independents have got nothing as they have gone and sold out to the larger parties later."

Uddhav's critics call it false bravado as Rane and Raj are expected to inflict damage on the Shiv Sena in urban Maharashtra, which is why he is concentrating on the rural areas. However, if they manage any harm, then Uddhav's attempts to transform the Sena into a modern party—which is a lot more inclusive and tolerant—will boomerang. His admission that

he does not want to "blindly follow" his father will also sound hollow if voters prefer Raj.

Keenly observing all the drama that is breaking out in Maharashtra is Gopinath Munde, the BJP's man in charge of the state election. Despite having won the Lok Sabha election from Beed, a win in Maharashtra will be Munde's return ticket to the state as deputy chief minister. After all the mess that has broken out in the party's central leadership, winning Maharashtra would mean a booster dose of sorts for the party. But in the end, only the fittest will survive this scourge. ■

RAJ AT AN
ELECTION
MEETING